EXPLORATORY CONCEPTS · AUGUST 2026

City Lifestyle

Where we'd look next

An outside read on your two stated priorities – publisher recruiting and social cross-sell – plus a third we'd add.

Not a proposal. A set of territories we think are worth exploring together.

WHAT WE HEARD

Two priorities, clearly stated

01

Recruit the right publishers

Your best publishers never went looking for this. They were spotted – like the Leawood publisher, who was tapped after growing a school swim team from 20 kids to 200. The hard part isn't selling the model. It's finding those people and staying in conversation long enough for them to picture it.

02

Get social advertising sold

The product works and the impressions are guaranteed. But print is a $900 relationship renewal and social is a $2,500 consultative sale – with an attribution question attached that most publishers don't want to answer, and most clients don't want to solve.

Everything that follows sits under one of these two – plus a third we'd put alongside them.

OUR READ

These are the same problem.

You recruit relationship people on purpose – and that's exactly right. It's why advertisers renew.

Then the model asks those same people to do seller things: to picture themselves as an entrepreneur and buy a franchise, and to run a consultative digital upsell with an analytics conversation attached.

Let publishers do relationships. Industrialize everything else at HQ.

PRIORITY ONE

Finding the people who don't know they want this

THE REFRAME

This is talent scouting, not lead generation

Franchise marketing selects for people actively shopping for a franchise. Your best publishers were not shopping for anything.

Who your funnel attracts

- Actively seeking a career change
- Motivated by escaping something
- Self-identifies as an entrepreneur
- Often new to the market
- Found you through a broker or portal

Who actually succeeds

- Wasn't looking for anything at all
- Already mobilizes people, unpaid
- Would never call herself a publisher
- Deep tenure and roots in the market
- Was tapped on the shoulder by someone

The signal you're screening for isn't "wants to own a business." It's "has mobilized a community without being paid to."

FLAGSHIP CONCEPT

The "Who Runs This Town" Index

A scored, named list of the people who actually make things happen in every market you serve – built from public signal, refreshed continuously, and usable by your team and your publishers.

1 Signals we harvest

- School PTO and booster boards
- Nonprofit boards, gala committees
- Local group admins and moderators
- Chamber and civic leadership rosters
- Micro-influencers by engagement rate
- Event and race organizers
- Career-break profiles with sales histories

2 What the score measures

- Mobilization – has she moved a group?
- Reach – how many people know her?
- Breadth – how many circles does she span?
- Tenure – how long in this market?
- Availability – capacity to take this on
- Adjacency – prior relationship-based work

3 What it produces

- A ranked, named shortlist per territory
- A refresh cadence, not a one-time pull
- A score attachable to any named person
- Coverage of open and future markets
- A shared language for "good candidate"

THE INDEX IN ACTION

Three ways the score earns its keep

1

Overlay it on your existing referral program

You already run referrals. Rather than replace it, we'd score it. When a publisher looks at their own network, they see your index score sitting next to the names – and the referral fee tiers up for higher-scoring people. Same program, aimed.

2

Hand publishers a scouting sheet, not a quota

For each open and adjacent market, a ranked shortlist of real, named people with the reasons they scored. Publishers confirm, correct, and warm-intro. Their local judgment sharpens the model; the model widens their field of view.

3

Feed the nomination engine

"Who Runs This Town" runs as public-facing editorial too: readers and publishers nominate the connectors who make things happen, and winners get profiled. Content you already need – and a flattered, warm, pre-qualified pipeline in every market.

Note: the referral program exists. The concept here is scoring and tiering what you already run – not building a new one.

IT ALREADY EXISTS

The index is running

A working build against real IRS filings. 10,812 people across 1,071 organizations, scored in four markets, ranked inside each one, every claim traceable to the filing it came from.

slt.ventures/wrtt

password: success

Markets

Territories under index · scored 22 Aug 2026

Overland Park — ACTIVE
KS · 8 ZIPs
PEOPLE 3,903 · ORGS 378

Franklin — ACTIVE
TN · 3 ZIPs
PEOPLE 3,154 · ORGS 328

Leawood — ACTIVE
KS · 4 ZIPs
PEOPLE 2,013 · ORGS 190

Fishers — TARGET
IN · 2 ZIPs
PEOPLE 1,742 · ORGS 175

R, A and X have no inputs in this run · weight removed from the denominator

Four markets, 10,812 people

Two Kansas suburbs, a Nashville suburb and an Indianapolis target territory. Coverage, not a demo dataset.

IRS Form 990, Part VII

Officers, directors and trustees, named and titled, signed under penalty of perjury. No scraping of anyone’s personal life.

Ranked inside the market

A score of 90 means near the top of this town, not of the country. A 12,000-household market and a 60,000 one are never compared.

Honest about what it can’t see

Reach, availability and adjacency need a licensed source and are switched off. Their weight leaves the denominator rather than counting as zero.

https://slt.ventures/wrtt · *password: success* · *click any market for the ranked sheet and the evidence behind every name.*

CLOSING THE BLIND SPOT

The organizers who never file

Public filings find the board chair. They cannot find the coach – and the coach may be the better publisher.

A coach whose team-gear order grows three years running has no board seat, no roster and no filing. But somebody sees her: the person who places the team order is the organizer, and that shows up in a manufacturer's transaction data.

Nobody will sell you a customer list, and they don't have to. Three standard structures move the audience without moving the data.

1 Shared audiences

The partner builds the segment inside their own Meta or Google account and shares it to yours. Native platform feature, no customer data changes hands. This is the ask.

START HERE

2 Co-op media

They run your creative against their own segment at a premium CPM. Simplest structure, and the one a brand's legal team clears fastest.

EASIEST YES

3 Clean-room match

LiveRamp or InfoSum, once volume justifies the overhead. Named here so nobody assumes it was missed, not because it is needed yet.

LATER

WHO ALREADY HOLDS IT

Team and league platforms (several already sell ads against team-admin audiences) · equipment and spirit-wear brands, where the order is placed by the organizer rather than the parents · PTA payment and sign-up tools · local event ticketing organizers.

CLOSING THE IDENTITY GAP

Never ask "want to be a publisher?" until the end

Nobody says yes to that cold. So ladder the asks – each one small – until she has already done the hardest part of the job and been paid for it.

1

Get featured

She's a subject, not a prospect. Zero commitment, entirely flattering.

2

Contribute

Suggest stories, nominate businesses in her own town. A live test of whether she can spot and connect.

3

Open the doors

Paid per meeting she sets with business owners she already knows. HQ runs a founding-advertiser round and does every close.

4

Own it

Offered once her own market has founding advertisers who have already said yes.

It also solves screening. At your entry cost, capital filters nobody – so let performance filter instead.

THE MESSAGE

The pitch is written for the wrong person

Today

Overworked. Missing family moments. Break away from the corporate grind.

Instead

You're already doing this job. You're just not getting paid for it.

She wasn't grinding – she was under-utilized. Her household didn't need the income.

What she's actually after

Identity outside of "mom." Status. A reason to use her brain. Flexibility that bends around school pickup.

What stops her

"I'm not a writer. I've never sold anything. I don't know media." She won't say it out loud – answer it before she has to.

How she pays for it

Ambassador earnings credited against the fee. She funds it with money she made doing the job – a much better kitchen-table conversation.

PRIORITY TWO

Selling social without asking publishers to sell

DIAGNOSIS

It isn't a training problem

You hired non-sellers deliberately – and correctly. Training won't close a structural mismatch, and turning her into a closer risks breaking the thing that works.

Different sale

Print renews on relationship. Social requires consultative selling, a needs conversation, and a business case. Same person, different sport.

Different price

$900 recurring and easy versus $2,500 and hard. Even with a strong ROI story, the ask is nearly three times bigger for a first-time yes.

Different objection

Clients want it tied to bookings. The fix – a pixel on their site – is a bigger ask than the budget. Publishers won't have that conversation, and clients won't take it on.

So don't fix the publisher. Change what she's being asked to do.

CONCEPT

Reduce her entire job to one sentence

"Would it be alright if I brought our digital person to coffee with you next Tuesday?"

1

She makes the introduction

The only thing she does, and the only thing she's uniquely good at. No pitch, no pricing, no analytics.

2

An HQ specialist runs the sale

A central digital team takes the call, handles objections, closes, manages the campaign and delivers the reporting.

3

She earns a referral override

Paid on the relationship she owns, without ever becoming a seller. Standard overlay structure in media.

4

The ask is one coffee a month

Not "sell social." Ten warm intros a year across every market is a very large number of at-bats.

FLAGSHIP CONCEPT

Attribution without infrastructure

The pixel is not the only path to proof. Five mechanics, none of which require the client to change anything on their website.

Call tracking numbers

A unique number in the social creative only. Volume, duration, recordings. For orthodontists, roofers, HVAC and med spas, the phone is the conversion.

Your own landing pages

Route social traffic to their City Lifestyle profile page instead of their site. Fully instrumented, owned end to end, zero client IT.

Google profile access

A two-minute, reversible "Manager" grant – far easier than a pixel – yielding calls, direction requests and clicks against campaign flights.

Customer-list matchback

"Export new customers this quarter" is a business request, not a technical one. Match to the household file: 61 of your 140 new patients.

Geo holdout tests

Withhold a slice of the footprint and compare. Requires nothing from the client – and at your scale it runs at category level.

CONCEPT

Change the product so it needs less selling

Bundle by default

Stop selling print and social as two decisions. Sell one presence package with print-only as the downgrade. An upsell becomes an opt-out – the most underused lever in packaging.

Build a $500 on-ramp

Every advertiser already gets a beautiful written and photographed feature. "Want more people in town to see it?" is the easiest sale in the company – and it doesn't look like an ad in-feed.

Make the report the product

What clients renew is confidence. Ship an automated one-page monthly report – and send print-only advertisers the version showing what they're missing. The report sells; she just brings it to coffee.

And check the commission math – if social pays like print, publishers are behaving rationally by ignoring it.

PRIORITY THREE · THE ONE YOU DIDN'T NAME

The asset you haven't started building yet

First-party data, identity, and the enterprise value that sits on top of it.

THE GAP

1.8M households.

Not one of them is a known person.

You deliver a premium product to the most affluent mailboxes in 200-plus defined geographies, every month. What you hold is a list of addresses – not identities, not interests, not behavior, and no consent to reach any of them anywhere else.

It caps your ad rates

Without identity you can't prove outcomes, so you sell guaranteed impressions and price defensively. Everything in Priority Two runs through this.

It blocks national money

Endemic and national advertisers buy audiences, not circulation. You can't sell a network audience you can't describe or address.

It's the enterprise value

A franchise network is valued on royalty streams. A consented, enriched graph of 1.8M affluent households is valued on something else entirely.

MOVE ONE – DO THIS FIRST

Own every link you print

Today a QR code or URL in the magazine goes straight to the advertiser. Route it through a domain you control instead. Nothing changes for the reader. Everything changes for you.

Printed QR or URL

Unique per advertiser, per placement, per issue, per market.

→

Your redirect layer

A short domain you own. Milliseconds. Invisible to the reader.

→

Advertiser destination

They get the traffic they were always getting – nothing to install.

What you get for essentially nothing

- Print attribution for the first time – which page, which issue, which market drove the click
- A per-advertiser performance story that renews the print buy, not just the social buy
- The first real behavioral signal on a reader, and the seed of the identity graph
- A shared measurement spine that Priority Two's reporting plugs straight into

Cheapest, fastest, highest-leverage thing on this page. It should ship before anything else in the deck.

MOVE TWO

Give readers a reason to identify themselves

Nobody hands over an email for a magazine they already receive free. They hand it over to vote, to enter, to get in, or to be first to know.

FLAGSHIP

Best of the City

An annual nomination-and-voting program in every market. It is the most welcome reason on earth to ask a resident for an email address – and it does four jobs at once:

- Consented emails plus declared local interests at scale
- Winners buy plaques, congratulations ads and a special issue
- An awards night with sponsors and ticket revenue
- A room full of exactly the people Priority One is hunting

The events calendar

The single most-wanted local utility. Sign up to get it weekly.

Ballots, polls and surveys

Declared interests – dining, home, health, schools – volunteered, not inferred.

Passes and giveaways

Restaurant week, home tours, ticket drops. Entry requires identity.

The digital edition

Early access and a personalized version, gated behind a light sign-in.

One caveat worth settling early: your franchise agreement decides whether HQ or the publisher owns this data. Answer that before anything gets built.

MOVE THREE

From a mailing list to a customer graph

Each layer is bought or built once and applies to all 200-plus markets. The value is in the stack, not any single piece.

1	**Household**	The delivery file you already own – address-level, hand-drawn geography, verified affluence.
2	**Identity**	Email, phone and device tied to household via the value exchange, address-keyed QR codes and the link layer.
3	**Enrichment**	Appended demographics, life stage, home value and tenure, income band, in-market and purchase-intent signals.
4	**Behavior**	Content affinities by category, click paths from print, email engagement, event attendance, offer redemption.
5	**The unified profile**	One governed, consented record per person and household – queryable, segmentable, exportable, and legally clean.

WHY IT'S WORTH DOING

What the graph pays for

Proof, finally

Customer-list matchback answers the attribution question that's blocking every social sale you're trying to make.

Higher rates, lower churn

Outcome selling instead of impression selling. Renewal stops depending on whether the publisher is liked.

Audience extension

CTV, addressable display and podcast against the real household file – inventory local advertisers want and can't buy.

National advertiser sales

The network audience becomes describable and addressable, which is the precondition for a national desk.

New movers

The highest-value local commerce audience there is, sellable as its own annual sponsorship category.

Better publisher scouting

The reader graph is also the candidate graph. Priority One's index gets sharper with behavioral data behind it.

And the one that matters most in a board meeting: it changes what the company is worth.

NEAR-TERM REVENUE – NO NEW PRODUCT REQUIRED

The national desk nobody is running

Your own advertiser lists are already full of national brands and franchise systems – buying one market at a time, sold by one publisher at a time. Nobody at HQ is selling them the network.

Already in your pages

- National home-services franchises – painting, closets, cleaning, restoration
- National homebuilders and developers
- Youth education and enrichment chains
- Building-products manufacturers
- National brokerage teams and lenders
- Live entertainment and ticketing

What changes

A small HQ desk sells network-wide and DMA-cluster buys directly to brands and franchisors, instead of leaving each one to be re-sold market by market.

How publishers stay whole

A defined revenue share back to the local publisher on every market in the buy. It has to be additive, or the field will fight it – and they'd be right to.

Why the graph multiplies it

National buyers purchase audiences, not circulation. Priority Three turns a distribution story into an addressable-audience story, which is what moves these budgets.

It also fits the thesis: this is revenue a publisher never has to sell.

IF ANY OF THIS LANDS

Four places we'd start

01
Own the link layer

Route every printed QR and URL through a domain you control. Cheap, fast, invisible to readers – and it starts the graph and gives print attribution for the first time.

02
Build the index

Score your existing publishers to find the real signal, then stand up ranked, named candidate lists for your top open markets. Overlay the scores onto the referral program you already run.

03
Design the ladder

Featured to contributor to paid door-opener to owner, all inside her own market, including the earn-in credit against the fee. Plus the nomination editorial that feeds it.

04
Prove social without pixels

Call tracking, instrumented profile pages and the automated monthly report – paired with an overlay specialist model so publishers only ever make an introduction.

Each one stands alone. Take any of them, or none.

Thank you

What you've built is genuinely hard to copy – 200-plus markets of real local relationships, and a product people actually look forward to receiving.

These are exploratory ideas from an outside vantage point. We'd be glad to pressure-test any of them with you.